

Lizards

Order Lacertilia

Rainbow lizard

Agama agama

- ↔ 12–16 in (30–40 cm)
- 📍 W., C., and E. Africa
- ⊗ Not known



Widespread in open countryside, this day-active lizard has strong limbs for climbing rocks and trees, where it hunts insects. During the breeding season, and especially in bright sunlight, males

develop their most vivid colors—an orange head and a blue body—to attract females.

This makes them one of the most distinctive of all African lizards. Rival males nod vigorously and sometimes clash with whipping tails.

Asian water dragon

Physignathus cocincinus

- ↔ 32–39 in (80–100 cm)
- 📍 SE. Asia (Thailand, Cambodia, and Vietnam)
- ⊗ Not known

This long-tailed lizard climbs trees in dense forests, usually in pool-side thickets. Its emerald green skin camouflages it in the foliage, but if disturbed, it jumps into the water. Here, it swims well and can remain submerged for nearly half an hour. Larger males develop head crests to impress the females. The dragon is an opportunistic feeder—it hunts smaller lizards but also grazes on vegetation.

North African mastigure

Uromastix acanthinura

- ↔ 12–16 in (30–41 cm)
- 📍 N. Africa
- ⊗ Not known

Mastigures are mainly plant-eaters. This species grazes on succulent desert vegetation, supplemented with occasional insects. It rarely drinks, getting the water it needs from the plants it eats. Like other mastigures, it lashes out with its thick, spiny tail when threatened by predators. It also uses its tail to block the entrance of its underground burrows and may even inflate its body to wedge itself inside.

Jackson's chameleon

Trioceros jacksonii

- ↔ 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
- 📍 E. Africa, introduced in Hawaii
- ⊗ Locally common

Like all chameleons, this lizard has eyes on turrets that can move independently of one another and an extendible, sticky-tipped tongue for catching insect prey. It is a large tree-dwelling species—opposable digits on its feet and a prehensile tail help it to grip branches. Males develop three head horns and flush with bright colors when courting females or showing off to rivals.

Smooth helmeted iguana

Corytophanes cristatus

- ↔ 12–16 in (30–41 cm)
- 📍 S. Mexico to N. South America
- ⊗ Not known

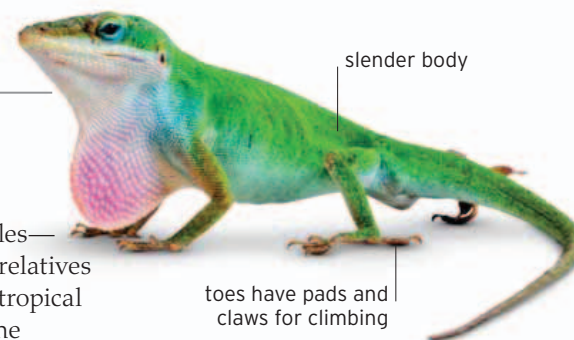
A group of mainly tree-climbing lizards, largely confined to the American tropics, iguanas have well-developed gripping feet, but their tails are not prehensile. One of many species with a head crest, or casque, this iguana can change its color. It runs quickly and may even scurry away on two hindlegs when fleeing from predators.

Green anole

Anolis carolinensis

- ↔ 5–8 in (13–20 cm)
- 📍 SE. US
- ⊗ Locally common

Nearly 400 species of anoles—small and medium-sized relatives of the iguanas—occur in tropical and subtropical parts of the Americas. The green anole is found further north than others and often frequents backyards in warmer US states. Like other anoles, it has a prominent fleshy colored fan on its throat—called a dewlap—that can be



erected for displaying to other members of the same species. The dewlap is larger in the males than in the females.

Green basilisk

Basiliscus plumifrons

- ↔ 24–30 in (61–76 cm)
- 📍 Central America
- ⊗ Locally common

A member of the so-called helmeted iguana family, this rainforest lizard climbs and swims well, hunting for insects and other small animals near river banks. It escapes

from predators by running away on its hindlegs. Its feet have flaps of skin, which trap bubbles of air as it scampers across pools of water—this ability to run on water has earned it the name “Jesus Christ lizard.” Green basilisks can live up to 10 years in captivity.

